

TERM: _____ WEEK: _____

NAME: _____



DA TUITION

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LITERARY MOVEMENTS

Romanticism



Discussion

What Matters Most?

For each pair, **HIGHLIGHT** the idea that you find more interesting or valuable. Be prepared to explain your choice.

1. **Reason and logic** OR **emotion and imagination**
2. **Busy cities** OR **wild natural landscapes**
3. **Following social expectations** OR **being an individual**
4. **Scientific explanations** OR **mystery and the supernatural**
5. **Order and control** OR **freedom and spontaneity**
6. **Modern technology** OR **a simpler way of life**



Nature

Imagine standing alone on a mountain during a thunderstorm. The clouds are dark, the wind is powerful, and the landscape seems endless.

1. What emotions might this experience create?

2. Could something frightening also be beautiful? Explain.

The Individual

A young person refuses to follow the career chosen for them by their family. Instead, they leave home to become an artist.

1. Is this character courageous, selfish or both?

2. Should people follow social expectations or their personal desires?

3. Why might writers celebrate characters who rebel against society?

Imagination

A scientist argues that only things that can be measured or proven are valuable. A poet argues that dreams, emotions and imagination reveal truths that science cannot explain.

1. Which person do you agree with more?

2. Can emotions teach us something important about human life?

3. Are there some experiences that cannot be explained using logic alone?

Progress

A factory brings jobs and new technology to a small town. However, it also destroys part of a forest and fills the air with smoke.

1. Is this progress?

2. What has the community gained?

3. What has the community lost?

Romanticism may be a movement that values...

And challenges ...

What is Romanticism?

Romanticism was an artistic, literary, and intellectual movement that **began in Europe in the late 18th century** and reached its strongest influence in the **early to mid-19th century**, often roughly dated from 1800 to 1850. It emerged partly in response to the **Enlightenment**, which emphasised reason and order, and partly in reaction to the **Industrial Revolution**, which transformed landscapes, labour, and everyday life

Romanticism influenced **poetry, novels, painting, music, and political thought**. In literature, it encouraged writers to focus on personal experience, emotional truth, and the power of imagination.

Romantic writers often valued:

- Romantics argued that human beings are not guided by logic alone. Deep feeling can reveal truths that reason cannot.
- Romanticists believed that imagination was a sacred, transformative power capable of revealing deeper truths about the world and the self than reason ever could, allowing artists and thinkers to reshape reality through vision, emotion, and creative expression.
- They saw nature not as a passive backdrop but as a living, spiritual force capable of inspiring awe, healing the soul, and reminding humanity of its smallness within a vast and sublime universe.
- Romanticists championed the unique self, valuing personal experience, emotional authenticity, and the right of the individual to think, feel, and create freely, often elevating the outsider, the dreamer, and the rebel above the conformist.
- They were drawn to what lay beyond rational explanation: dreams, ghosts, omens, ruined places, and unseen realms, seeing mystery and spirituality as essential dimensions of human experience that science alone could not capture.
- Many Romanticists opposed rigid class structures, political oppression, and artistic conformity, viewing rebellion against authority as a moral and creative act necessary for the liberation of both the individual and society.
- They feared that industrialisation, mechanisation, and rapid urban growth were severing people from nature, authentic emotion, and spiritual life, replacing genuine human experience with cold efficiency, polluted landscapes, and alienated labour.



emotion over
pure reason



imagination and
creativity



the beauty and
power of nature



individuality and
personal freedom



mystery, spirituality
and the supernatural



rebellion against
social restrictions



concern about
industrialisation and
modern progress

Core Romanticism Themes



NATURE

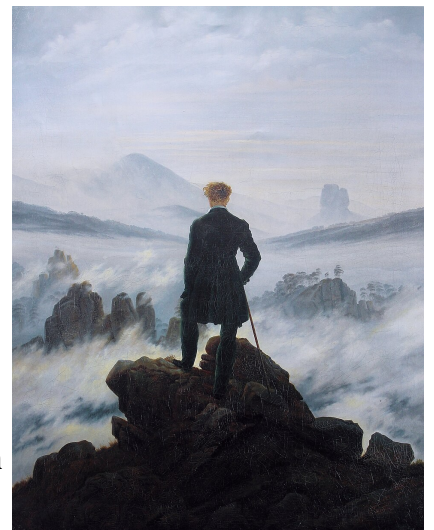
Romantic composers rejected the idea that nature was merely a passive setting or a collection of resources to be controlled by humans. Instead, nature could act as a teacher, healer and spiritual presence, offering individuals wisdom that could not be gained through institutions or scientific reasoning alone. Landscapes often reflect a character's emotional state, with calm natural settings suggesting peace and harmony, while storms, darkness and hostile environments express fear, conflict or psychological disturbance.

However, nature is not always presented as gentle or protective. It may also appear powerful, unpredictable and destructive, reminding humanity of its weakness. Romantic texts therefore explore both humanity's connection to nature and its inability to fully understand or control it.

THE SUBLIME

The sublime describes an experience of overwhelming beauty, power or terror that exceeds ordinary human understanding. Romantic composers often depict enormous mountains, violent storms, oceans, glaciers, ruins and vast night skies to produce a mixture of admiration and fear. Faced with such landscapes, the individual may feel spiritually elevated while also becoming aware of their own physical smallness.

The sublime challenges the belief that reason can explain everything. It suggests that some experiences are so immense or emotionally powerful that they can only be felt rather than logically understood. In Romantic texts, encounters with the sublime may inspire wonder and self-discovery, but they can also lead to fear, isolation or a dangerous desire to conquer forces beyond human control.



IMAGINATION

Romanticism presents imagination as more than fantasy or entertainment. It is a creative, intellectual and moral power that allows individuals to see beyond the limitations of everyday reality. Through imagination, ordinary experiences can become meaningful, nature can appear alive and individuals can envision alternatives to political oppression, social conformity and materialism.

Imagination may also provide comfort, allowing people to preserve beautiful experiences or escape painful circumstances. However, Romantic composers sometimes question whether imagination can become dangerous when it separates an individual from reality. Ambitious dreamers, artists and inventors may create extraordinary things, yet their visions can also lead to obsession, irresponsibility or destruction.

EMOTION AND MEMORY

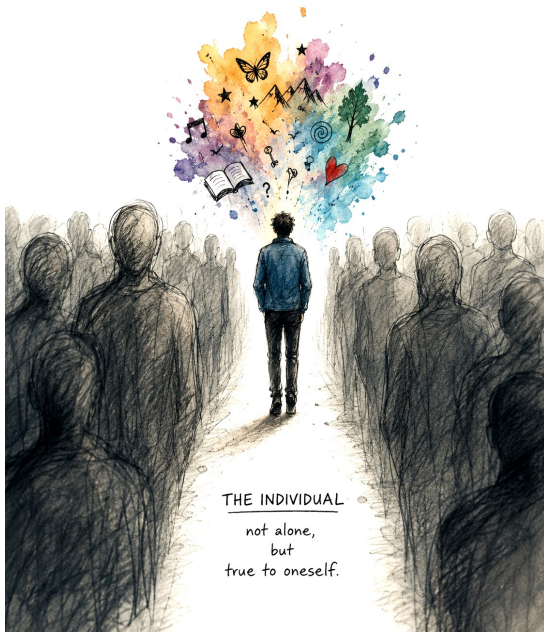
Romantic composers challenged the Enlightenment belief that reason should dominate human behaviour. They argued that intense emotions such as love, grief, wonder, fear and loneliness could reveal truths about human experience that logic alone could not express. Poetry and prose often focus on private emotional states, allowing readers to enter the consciousness of the individual.



Memory is closely connected to emotion because past experiences can continue to influence the present. Recollections of childhood, nature, love or loss may provide comfort and spiritual renewal. Yet memory can also be unreliable or painful. It may reshape an experience, idealise what has been lost or trap an individual in regret. Romantic texts therefore explore memory as both a source of emotional strength and a reminder that time cannot be reversed.

THE INDIVIDUAL

Romanticism values the unique experiences, emotions and imagination of the individual. Romantic protagonists are often wanderers, rebels, artists, outcasts or misunderstood figures who reject society's expectations. Their independence allows them to challenge injustice, pursue knowledge or develop a deeper understanding of themselves and the natural world.



However, the Romantic individual is not always heroic. A rejection of society may become loneliness, selfishness or arrogance. Characters who believe themselves superior to ordinary people may ignore their responsibilities towards others. Romantic texts therefore celebrate personal freedom while also questioning what occurs when individual desire is pursued without empathy, restraint or accountability.

FREEDOM AND REVOLT

Many Romantic writers were influenced by political revolutions and movements that challenged monarchy, class inequality and inherited authority. Their texts frequently support liberty, individual rights and resistance to oppression. Rebels and outsiders may be presented as courageous figures who refuse to accept unjust laws, restrictive traditions or systems that limit human potential.

Nevertheless, Romantic attitudes towards revolution were complex. The violence and instability that followed some political uprisings caused writers to question whether rebellion always produced genuine freedom. Romantic texts may therefore celebrate the hope of revolution while also exposing the danger of uncontrolled power, revenge and social disorder. Freedom is presented as valuable, but it must be accompanied by moral responsibility.

CHILDHOOD AND INNOCENCE

Romantic composers often present childhood as a period of imaginative freedom, emotional honesty and closeness to nature. Unlike adults, who may be shaped by social expectations, education and material ambition, children are represented as possessing an instinctive ability to experience wonder. Their perspective can reveal beauty and meaning in things that adults have learned to ignore.

However, childhood innocence is also fragile. Poverty, industrialisation, institutional control and adult cruelty may corrupt or destroy it. Some Romantic texts idealise childhood as a lost state that adults attempt to recover through memory. Others use the suffering of children to criticise societies that claim to be civilised while failing to protect their most vulnerable members.

THE SUPERNATURAL

Romantic writers were fascinated by experiences that could not be easily explained through science or reason. Ghosts, dreams, omens, monsters, visions and mysterious events allowed composers to explore the unknown and challenge the limits of rational thought. Supernatural elements often create uncertainty, making readers question whether an event is real, imagined or produced by psychological disturbance.

The supernatural can also symbolise hidden fears, guilt or desires. A monster may represent the consequences of rejected responsibility, while a haunting may suggest that the past cannot remain buried. Rather than simply frightening audiences, the supernatural allows Romantic texts to investigate the darker areas of the human mind and the possibility that reality contains forces beyond human understanding.



The Romantic Era: Key Events Timeline

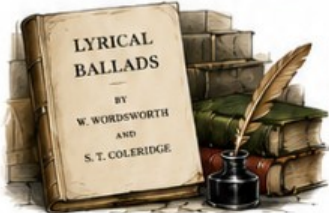
1789–c.1850



1789

French Revolution begins

The French Revolution inspired many writers. It spread ideas about freedom, equality, and the importance of the individual.



1798

Lyrical Ballads published

Wordsworth and Coleridge's book helped begin English Romanticism. It encouraged everyday language and poetry based on personal feeling.



1807

'I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud'

This poem shows the Romantic love of nature. The daffodils become a memory that brings the speaker joy.



1818

Frankenstein published

Mary Shelley combined Romantic ideas with Gothic fiction and science. The novel warns that ambition without responsibility can be dangerous.



1819

'Ode to the West Wind'

Shelley uses the wind as a symbol of change and revolution. The poem connects nature, imagination, and political hope.



1820

'Ode to a Nightingale'

Keats explores beauty, sadness, and the wish to escape suffering through art. The poem reflects the Romantic focus on deep feeling.



1824

Death of Byron in Greece

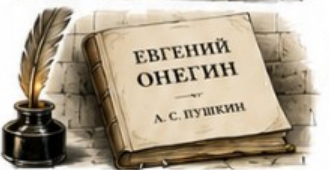
Byron died while supporting Greek independence. His life and death helped create the image of the passionate, rebellious Romantic hero.



1831

Notre-Dame de Paris

Victor Hugo spread Romanticism across Europe. His novel celebrates the medieval past and values people who are often ignored.



1833

Eugene Onegin serialised

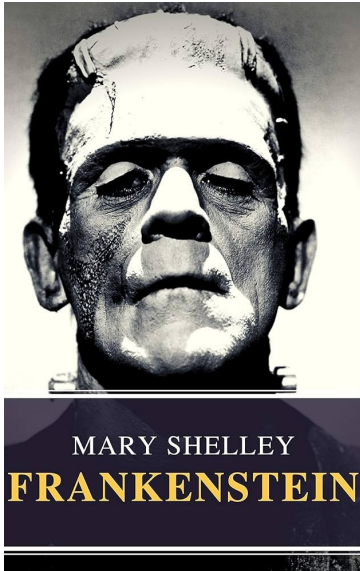
Pushkin's verse novel became a major work of Russian literature. It links Romanticism with national identity, local culture, and everyday society.



c. 1850

Realism supplants Romanticism

By the mid-1800s, Realism became more popular. Even so, Romantic ideas about nature, imagination, and individuality continued to influence later writers and artists.



Mary Shelley's

FRANKENSTEIN

(1818)

Victor Frankenstein, long fascinated with the secrets of life, death and scientific discovery, has constructed a creature out of dead body parts. At this point in the novel Frankenstein recalls the moment he witnessed his creature coming to life.

– FROM CHAPTER 5 –

It was on a dreary night of November that I beheld the accomplishment of my toils. With an anxiety that almost amounted to agony, I collected the instruments of life around me, that I might infuse a spark of being into the lifeless thing that lay at my feet. It was already one in the morning; the rain pattered dismally against the panes, and my candle was nearly burnt out, when, by the glimmer of the half-extinguished light, I saw the dull yellow eye of the creature open; it breathed hard, and a convulsive motion agitated its limbs.

How can I describe my emotions at this catastrophe, or how delineate the wretch whom with such infinite pains and care I had endeavoured to form? His limbs were in proportion, and I had selected his features as beautiful. Beautiful! Great God! His yellow skin scarcely covered the work of muscles and arteries beneath; his hair was of a lustrous black, and flowing; his teeth of a pearly whiteness; but these luxuriances only formed a more horrid contrast with his watery eyes, that seemed almost of the same colour as the dun-white sockets in which they were set, his shrivelled complexion and straight black lips.

The different accidents of life are not so changeable as the feelings of human nature. I had worked hard for nearly two years, for the sole purpose of infusing life into an inanimate body. For this I had deprived myself of rest and health. I had desired it with an ardour that far exceeded moderation; but now that I had finished, the beauty of the dream vanished, and breathless horror and disgust filled my heart. Unable to endure the aspect of the being I had created, I rushed out of the room and continued a long time traversing my bed-chamber, unable to compose my mind to sleep. At length lassitude succeeded to the tumult I had before endured, and I threw myself on the bed in my clothes, endeavouring to seek a few moments of forgetfulness. But it was in vain; I slept, indeed, but I was disturbed by the wildest dreams. I thought I saw Elizabeth, in the bloom of health, walking in the streets of Ingolstadt. Delighted and surprised, I embraced her, but as I imprinted the first kiss on her lips, they became livid with the hue of death; her features appeared to change, and I thought that I held the corpse of my dead mother in my arms; a shroud enveloped her form, and I saw the grave-worms crawling in the folds of the flannel. I started from my sleep with horror; a cold dew covered my forehead, my teeth chattered, and every limb became convulsed; when, by the dim and yellow light of the moon, as it forced its way through the window shutters, I beheld the wretch—the miserable monster whom I had created. He held up the curtain of the bed; and his eyes, if eyes they may be called, were fixed on me.

His jaws opened, and he muttered some inarticulate sounds, while a grin wrinkled his cheeks. He might have spoken, but I did not hear; one hand was stretched out, seemingly to detain me, but I escaped and rushed downstairs. I took refuge in the courtyard belonging to the house which I inhabited, where I remained during the rest of the night, walking up and down in the greatest agitation, listening attentively, catching and fearing each sound as if it were to announce the approach of the demoniacal corpse to which I had so miserably given life.

Oh! No mortal could support the horror of that countenance. A mummy again endued with animation could not be so hideous as that wretch. I had gazed on him while unfinished; he was ugly then, but when those muscles and joints were rendered capable of motion, it became a thing such as even Dante could not have conceived.

I passed the night wretchedly. Sometimes my pulse beat so quickly and hardly that I felt the palpitation of every artery; at others, I nearly sank to the ground through languor and extreme weakness. Mingled with this horror, I felt the bitterness of disappointment; dreams that had been my food and pleasant rest for so long a space were now become a hell to me; and the change was so rapid, the overthrow so complete!

1. Which feature of Romanticism is most clearly established in the opening sentence, “It was on a dreary night of November”?

- A. Celebration of urban progress
- B. Interest in dark and emotionally charged settings
- C. Preference for logic and scientific certainty
- D. Rejection of the supernatural

2. The description of the rain pattering “dismally against the panes” is an example of:

- A. Pathetic fallacy
- B. Euphemism
- C. Satire
- D. Allegory

3. Victor’s attempt to “infuse a spark of being into the lifeless thing” most strongly reflects the Romantic concern with:

- A. Childhood innocence
- B. Political equality
- C. The Supernatural
- D. Social class and inherited wealth

4. What does Victor’s reaction to the Creature’s awakening suggest?

- A. Scientific achievement always produces happiness
- B. Imagination is less powerful than reason
- C. Human beings can completely control nature
- D. Ambition may become destructive when it is not guided by responsibility

5. Which quotation best demonstrates the sudden collapse of Victor’s idealised dream?

- A. “My candle was nearly burnt out”
- B. “His limbs were in proportion”
- C. “The beauty of the dream vanished”
- D. “I took refuge in the courtyard”

6. The repeated references to Victor's intense fear, horror and agitation reflect the Romantic emphasis on:

- A. Emotional experience
- B. Economic progress
- C. Social conformity
- D. Objective narration

7. Which statement best explains how the extract challenges Enlightenment ideas?

- A. It presents scientific knowledge as simple and reliable.
- B. It argues that emotion should be completely ignored.
- C. It questions whether reason and scientific progress can control every consequence.
- D. It suggests that natural laws have no influence on human life.

Explain how the setting creates a threatening or unsettling mood. Refer to one example from the extract. (2 marks)

Explain how the phrase "the beauty of the dream vanished" reflects a Romantic warning about ambition. (3 marks)

Analyse how the Creature is presented as both human and unnatural in the extract. (4 marks)

The Raven– Edgar Allen Poe

Once upon a midnight dreary, while I pondered, weak and weary,
Over many a quaint and curious volume of forgotten lore—

While I nodded, nearly napping, suddenly there came a tapping,
As of some one gently rapping, rapping at my chamber door.

“Tis some visitor,” I muttered, “tapping at my chamber door—
Only this and nothing more.”

Ah, distinctly I remember it was in the bleak December;
And each separate dying ember wrought its ghost upon the floor.

Eagerly I wished the morrow;—vainly I had sought to borrow
From my books surcease of sorrow—sorrow for the lost Lenore—
For the rare and radiant maiden whom the angels name Lenore—
Nameless *here* for evermore.

And the silken, sad, uncertain rustling of each purple curtain
Thrilled me—filled me with fantastic terrors never felt before;

So that now, to still the beating of my heart, I stood repeating
“Tis some visitor entreating entrance at my chamber door—
Some late visitor entreating entrance at my chamber door;—
This it is and nothing more.”

Presently my soul grew stronger; hesitating then no longer,
“Sir,” said I, “or Madam, truly your forgiveness I implore;
But the fact is I was napping, and so gently you came rapping,
And so faintly you came tapping, tapping at my chamber door,
That I scarce was sure I heard you”—here I opened wide the door;—
Darkness there and nothing more.

Deep into that darkness peering, long I stood there wondering, fearing,
Doubting, dreaming dreams no mortal ever dared to dream before;

But the silence was unbroken, and the stillness gave no token,
And the only word there spoken was the whispered word, “Lenore?”
This I whispered, and an echo murmured back the word, “Lenore!”—
Merely this and nothing more.

Back into the chamber turning, all my soul within me burning,
Soon again I heard a tapping somewhat louder than before.

“Surely,” said I, “surely that is something at my window lattice;
Let me see, then, what thereat is, and this mystery explore—
Let my heart be still a moment and this mystery explore;—
’Tis the wind and nothing more!”



Back into the chamber turning, all my soul within me burning,
Soon again I heard a tapping somewhat louder than before.

“Surely,” said I, “surely that is something at my window lattice;
Let me see, then, what thereat is, and this mystery explore—
Let my heart be still a moment and this mystery explore;—
'Tis the wind and nothing more!”

Open here I flung the shutter, when, with many a flirt and flutter,
In there stepped a stately Raven of the saintly days of yore;
Not the least obeisance made he; not a minute stopped or stayed he;
But, with mien of lord or lady, perched above my chamber door—
Perched upon a bust of Pallas just above my chamber door—
Perched, and sat, and nothing more.

Then this ebony bird beguiling my sad fancy into smiling,
By the grave and stern decorum of the countenance it wore,
“Though thy crest be shorn and shaven, thou,” I said, “art sure no craven,
Ghastly grim and ancient Raven wandering from the Nightly shore—
Tell me what thy lordly name is on the Night’s Plutonian shore!”
Quoth the Raven “Nevermore.”

Much I marvelled this ungainly fowl to hear discourse so plainly,
Though its answer little meaning—little relevancy bore;
For we cannot help agreeing that no living human being
Ever yet was blessed with seeing bird above his chamber door—
Bird or beast upon the sculptured bust above his chamber door,
With such name as “Nevermore.”

But the Raven, sitting lonely on the placid bust, spoke only
That one word, as if his soul in that one word he did outpour.
Nothing farther then he uttered—not a feather then he fluttered—
Till I scarcely more than muttered “Other friends have flown before—
On the morrow *he* will leave me, as my Hopes have flown before.”
Then the bird said “Nevermore.”

Startled at the stillness broken by reply so aptly spoken,
“Doubtless,” said I, “what it utters is its only stock and store
Caught from some unhappy master whom unmerciful Disaster
Followed fast and followed faster till his songs one burden bore—
Till the dirges of his Hope that melancholy burden bore
Of ‘Never—nevermore’.”

But the Raven still beguiling all my fancy into smiling,
Straight I wheeled a cushioned seat in front of bird, and bust and door;
Then, upon the velvet sinking, I betook myself to linking
Fancy unto fancy, thinking what this ominous bird of yore—
What this grim, ungainly, ghastly, gaunt, and ominous bird of yore
Meant in croaking “Nevermore.”

This I sat engaged in guessing, but no syllable expressing
To the fowl whose fiery eyes now burned into my bosom’s core;
This and more I sat divining, with my head at ease reclining
On the cushion’s velvet lining that the lamp-light gloated o’er,
But whose velvet-violet lining with the lamp-light gloating o’er,
She shall press, ah, nevermore!

Then, methought, the air grew denser, perfumed from an unseen censer
Swung by Seraphim whose foot-falls tinkled on the tufted floor.
“Wretch,” I cried, “thy God hath lent thee—by these angels he hath sent
thee
Respite—respite and nepenthe from thy memories of Lenore;
Quaff, oh quaff this kind nepenthe and forget this lost Lenore!”
Quoth the Raven “Nevermore.”

“Prophet!” said I, “thing of evil!—prophet still, if bird or devil!—
Whether Tempter sent, or whether tempest tossed thee here ashore,
Desolate yet all undaunted, on this desert land enchanted—
On this home by Horror haunted—tell me truly, I implore—
Is there—*is* there balm in Gilead?—tell me—tell me, I implore!”
Quoth the Raven “Nevermore.”

“Prophet!” said I, “thing of evil!—prophet still, if bird or devil!
By that Heaven that bends above us—by that God we both adore—
Tell this soul with sorrow laden if, within the distant Aidenn,
It shall clasp a sainted maiden whom the angels name Lenore—
Clasp a rare and radiant maiden whom the angels name Lenore.”
Quoth the Raven “Nevermore.”

“Be that word our sign of parting, bird or fiend!” I shrieked, upstarting—
“Get thee back into the tempest and the Night’s Plutonian shore!
Leave no black plume as a token of that lie thy soul hath spoken!
Leave my loneliness unbroken!—quit the bust above my door!
Take thy beak from out my heart, and take thy form from off my door!”
Quoth the Raven “Nevermore.”

And the Raven, never flitting, still is sitting, *still* is sitting
On the pallid bust of Pallas just above my chamber door;
And his eyes have all the seeming of a demon's that is dreaming,
And the lamp-light o'er him streaming throws his shadow on the floor;
And my soul from out that shadow that lies floating on the floor
Shall be lifted—nevermore!



1. Summarise what is happening in the poem (2 marks)

2. What does the speaker's whispered repetition of Lenore's name reveal about his state of mind? (2 marks)

3. Analyse how the repeated response "Nevermore" changes in meaning as the poem progresses. (3 marks)

4. Analyse how Poe presents memory as both an expression of love and a source of suffering. Refer to the speaker's recollections of Lenore and his inability to forget her. (5 marks)

[illegible]

5. How does *The Raven* reflect the Romantic belief that intense emotion can overpower reason? Support your response with detailed textual evidence. (5 marks)

[illegible]